
Preface

Meeting the authors of books I have read still feels like meeting a celebrity to me, no matter how many times I do it. When I was a Ph.D student, I read Andrew Gelman’s book on Bayesian statistics, and was impressed when my advisor, Daniel F. Heitjan, mentioned knowing him. I think he said something like “[Andrew] is like my little brother. What did he do that you’re so impressed by?”¹, to which I responded that he wrote the Bayesian textbook we used in class. “Lots of people write books,” said Dr. Heitjan. This was the first moment that I actually began to consider the possibility that perhaps I, too, might write a book someday.

Some time later, I attended a coffee social at the Joint Statistical Meetings (honestly, mostly for the free coffee), and happened to run into Roger Berger. Having extensively studied from the book “Statistical Inference” that Dr. Berger wrote with George Casella, I was very excited about this meeting (see Figure 1).



FIGURE 1: Me (MaryLena Bleile, left) meeting Roger Berger (right) at JSM in 2023. Note that I am very happy.

After the interaction with Dr. Berger ended, I was very happy, and began to be extremely friendly and sociable with the others at the coffee session. One of the random people I approached for conversation was Lara Spieker, an editor for CRC press (as I write this, it occurs to me that the coffee session was hosted by CRC Press, who also published “Statistical Inference” - I suppose that may be why Roger Berger was there). Anyway, Lara mentioned searching for new potential authors/contracts for CRC Press, and I volunteered a book idea I had for unifying Causal Inference and Reinforcement Learning. As a 26-year-old postdoc at the time, I would ordinarily not have been so bold as to make the suggestion, but I was still very happy about having met Roger Berger. This, combined with a recollection of Dr. Heitjan’s phrase “lots of people write books” gave me the required confidence.

As you may have noticed, Lara Spieker is the editor on this book, which is published by CRC press. I wish to thank her enormously for taking the chance on me, and for her

¹This is not an exact quote; accuracy is subject to my fleeting memory...

ongoing editorial support. My gratitude similarly extends to the editorial board at CRC Press, and to the two anonymous reviewers for their thoughtful and encouraging comments which greatly enhanced the quality of the book.

I wrote a good deal of this book while living with my friend Alysha Behn, who is an outstanding software engineer and writer. “Optimal Control Using Causal Agents” would not be what it is without her material, emotional, and intellectual support. I also wish to thank my partner, Shaker Zaman: Dating any writer - never mind a *statistician* - is not an entry-level job, and Shaker has exhibited an infinite supply of patience for my digressions. I also owe a great deal to my father, for his ongoing support throughout college and beyond; thank you so much for believing in me, and for your incredible patience and generosity.

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...oh and Roger Berger, of course.